CONDOR LEGION

"Volunteers" from the armed forces of Germany and Italy supported the Nationalists throughout the civil war. The Italians were more numerous, but the Germans were more effective. Organized into the Condor Legion from November 1936, the German intervention force consisted primarily of Luftwaffe aircraft and pilots. There was also a contingent of light tanks and of 88mm artillery used in an anti-aircraft and antitank role.

Nazi leaders saw the war as a testing ground for new equipment and tactics. The Junkers Ju 87 Stuka dive-bomber and the Messerschmitt Bf-109 fighter were two aircraft blooded in Spain that would prove crucial in the opening phase of World War II. The Luftwaffe gained experience in air-to-air combat and in providing air support to ground forces. The Condor Legion was infamously responsible for the destruction of the Basque town of Guernica by aerial bombardment in April 1937. Personnel serving with the Legion were well paid by their government and returned to Germany as a combat-hardened elite.



Messerschmitt Bf-109D
Many Luftwaffe pilots and aircraft such as the Messerschmitt Bf-109D saw their first combat with the Condor Legion in Spain.

INTERNATIONAL BRIGADES

From late 1936 the Soviet Union organized International Brigades to fight against fascism in Spain. Enthusiastic volunteers from many countries, including France, Italy, Germany, Poland, Britain, and the United States, joined up in Paris and were moved clandestinely into Spain. The first Brigades were ready in time to play a crucial part in the defence of Madrid in November 1936. Through 1937–38 thousands lost their lives in futile frontal offensives. Others were executed by communist officers for deviation from the correct political line or for desertion. The Brigades were disbanded in September 1938, those who remained being integrated into the Republican People's Army. Out of 60,000 volunteers, 10,000 died in Spain.

LOYALISTS

At the start of the civil war the government had the support of loyal units of the regular army and of the majority of the paramilitary Assault Guards. But the Republic's survival depended upon the creation of people's militias by a variety of left-wing groups, chief among them the anarchist and socialist trade union movements. Seizing weapons from army depots, they secured major cities and mounted a defence against the Nationalist forces, while simultaneously trying to carry through a social revolution. The militias were run on strictly democratic lines, with the election of officers and a total lack of formal discipline. At times they performed with outstanding bravery, but the militias were probably too unreliable to fight a long war of attrition against Franco's regulars.

Perhaps surprisingly, no one considered mounting a guerrilla campaign against the Nationalists. Instead, the Republican government insisted on creating a conventional army to fight a conventional war. The People's Army integrated the popular militias, loyal pre-civil war troops, and fresh conscripts from Republican-controlled areas. It was watched over by political commissars who were almost exclusively communist. With the Soviet Union supplying the Republic with arms and specialist personnel, the influence of the communists, at first a minority, rapidly increased.

In-fighting between left-wing groups within the army hampered its effectiveness. Although brave and stubborn, the troops were poorly led, often thrown away in overambitious offensives. It was a weary and demoralized army that finally surrendered in March 1939.



Propaganda poster
"1st win the war: fewer wasted words!" urges a 1937 poster – a reference to the in-fighting between left-wing groups that undermined the Loyalist cause.



Hotchkiss Mle 1914
The French-manufactured Hotchkiss machine-gun saw service with both sides in the Spanish Civil War.

> "A BATTLE IS IN PROGRESS NOT MERELY TO DEFEND A PEOPLE FROM A SAVAGE AGGRESSOR, BUT TO DESTROY SOMETHING THAT ... WILL ... CRUSH THE PEOPLE OF ALL DEMOCRATIC COUNTRIES."
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> **BILL PAYNTER**, BRITISH INTERNATIONAL BRIGADES MEMBER, MAY 1937